



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Divine Mercy Academy
School Website: <https://divinemercy.md/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Divine Mercy Academy (DMA) in Maryland presents a robust CLASSICAL orientation. The school explicitly identifies itself as a classical K–8 school using the Catholic Liberal Education model, emphasizing formation of Saints and Scholars, wonder, virtue, and the integration of faith and reason across disciplines. The public materials repeatedly foreground Catholic liturgical life, theology, moral formation, and a Trivium-based curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric) with deliberate Great Books/Great Works reading and a community-centered, family-partnered approach. Taken together, this signals a strong alignment with the classical education rubric, including religious/metaphysical foundations, formation-focused purpose, liberal-arts curriculum, contemplative and Socratic pedagogy at higher levels, a living-faculty model, and an emphasis on parent involvement as co-educators.

Overall assessment: CLASSICAL

- The site's core messaging centers on: Catholic identity, liturgical life, and formation; a deliberately integrated liberal-arts curriculum built on Great Books; the Trivium in pedagogy; a strong emphasis on virtue, wisdom, and wonder; and active partnerships with families. See evidence of Catholic liturgy and theology, Great Books/cultivation of virtue, Trivium-based pedagogy, living-faculty framing, and explicit parent partnership. For example, DMA states its purpose as "to know, love, and serve God" and describes a Catholic liberal-arts curriculum with Great Works and wonder guiding learning, alongside the Trivium progression and a liturgical life.
- What would move the needle for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL schools is not required here; DMA already demonstrates a strong Classical Catholic profile. If anything, continued explicit articulation of the Great Conversation and further documentation of direct classroom practices (e.g., specific Socratic activities by grade) would make the alignment even more transparent. (No major needle-moving changes are required for a CLASSICAL rating.)

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - DMA identifies itself as a Catholic liberal-arts school and foregrounds formation in faith, liturgical life, and Theology. The messaging emphasizes regular Mass, daily prayer, liturgical celebrations, and Catholic moral teaching grounded in the Catechism. For example, materials describe a Catholic, classical education rooted in Catholic tradition, with regular Mass and adoration, and explicit aims to know, love, and serve God. - The school's own narrative ties education to the Eucharist and Christ-centered formation, situating education as ordered toward Heaven and sanctity.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present (e.g., Catholic; liturgical; Mass; adoration; Eucharist; Theology; Catholic Tradition; liturgical year; sacred tradition). - Negative keywords present: none detected in the public materials for this category.

Why this rating - The school explicitly centers Catholic doctrine, liturgical practice, and formation in faith as core to the educational project, aligning strongly with the Religious and Metaphysical Foundations rubric. The presence of Mass, daily prayer, liturgical celebrations, and theology integration signals a full alignment with the foundational elements.

Sources for evidence: DMA's statements about Catholic liberal education, Mass/Adoration, liturgical life, and the Eucharist as ordered toward Christ.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - DMA states the goal of education as formation of saints and scholars, with a mission to know, love, and serve God and to form others who do the same; the aim is virtue and wisdom, not simply job preparation. The school emphasizes formation over information and a liberal-arts goal of freedom for truth through wonder. - The narrative repeatedly frames education as a journey of formation, not merely acquisition of curricular content, with emphasis on virtue, wisdom, and wonder.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation; virtue; wisdom; truth; wonder; love of learning; liberal education; unity of faith and reason; glory of God; Great Books (as part of formation through the Great Conversation). - Negative keywords present: none detected that would indicate a non-formation or job-centric focus.

Why this rating - The school explicitly positions education as formation toward virtue and wisdom, grounded in truth, goodness, and beauty, rather than primarily job preparation. The language of "Saints and Scholars," "formation," and the unity of faith and reason aligns with a CLASSICAL orientation.

Sources for evidence: Mission statements and descriptions of formation, Great Books approach, and the emphasis on "formation of virtue" and "great books."

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - DMA's curriculum is described as a Catholic Liberal Education model with a liberal-arts program, integrating theology, literature, history, mathematics, science, and the arts, and cultivating virtue through Great Works. The curriculum is said to be built on the study of great stories and great books, curated from the Great Works of Literature, with a mission to form Saints and Scholars. - DMA explicitly references the Trivium (Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric) as a framework, and notes that lower grammar stage emphasizes memorization and song, while upper levels emphasize rhetoric, reasoning, and public speaking. It also highlights Latin, music, and the arts as part of a holistic curriculum. - There is explicit emphasis on the Great Books/Great Conversation and wonder as curricular drivers.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts; Great Books; Great Works of Literature; Trivium (Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric); wonder; formation through the arts; faith-integrated curriculum; Latin; music; humanities; theology; history; mathematics; science. - Negative keywords present: none detected in the public materials that would indicate a lack of Great Books or liberal-arts emphasis.

Why this rating - The curriculum is clearly described as a liberal-arts classical program with explicit Great Books/Great Works, Trivium, and integration of faith with reason, which aligns squarely with CLASSICAL criteria.

Sources for evidence: Curriculum description, Great Books emphasis, Trivium, and integrated Catholic liberal-arts approach.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - DMA describes a dual approach: lower-school pedagogy emphasizes memory, singing, and chanting to deepen memory and delight, while upper-school pedagogy features Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, and rhetoric training. The Trivium framework is central to pedagogy, with explicit stages (Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric) and practice in public speaking and rhetoric. - The liturgical and wonder-centered approach is woven into pedagogy (formation by wonder, catechesis, and Catholic formation). - The school notes that upper-level students are trained in rhetoric and have opportunities to give speeches, matching the classical emphasis on public speaking and dialectic.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: singing/chants in lower grades; memory; contemplation; Socratic discussion; seminars; debates; rhetoric; public speaking; wonder; formation. - Negative keywords present: none clearly evident in public materials for pedagogy that would indicate a departure from classical methods.

Why this rating - The explicit articulation of grade-appropriate forms of pedagogy (song/memory in early grades; Socratic/seminar/rhetoric in higher grades) aligns with classical teaching methods.

Sources for evidence: “Lower grammar stage: memorization, story, song” and “upper school: Socratic discussion, seminars, debates; rhetoric training.”

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The DMA materials describe the faculty as instructors who model virtue and form a “living curriculum” and who are integral to the school’s mission and culture. The faculty page emphasizes a community of mentors and collaborative, faith-centered instruction. - Descriptions emphasize that faculty are “on fire for our mission,” dedicated to faith, and guiding students in intellectual and spiritual growth, reflecting the classical model of teachers as virtuous exemplars and living curriculum.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum; model teachers; mentors; virtue; faith-centered culture; collaborative faculty; citizens of a Catholic intellectual tradition. - Negative keywords present: none detected.

Why this rating - The faculty is framed as a core, virtuous, and collaborative component of the educational enterprise, aligning with the classical ideal of the teacher as exemplar and living curriculum.

Sources for evidence: Faculty descriptions and statements about mission-driven, virtuous teaching.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - DMA emphasizes partnership with families and positions parents as the primary educators, inviting families to participate through tours, open houses, shadow visits, and parent resources. The school explicitly treats parents as co-educators and seeks to educate parents about classical education via the website and gatherings. - The parent/community materials include references to family resources, calendar, Catholic cultural association, uniforms/handbook, and opportunities for family formation. This demonstrates a community-centered approach consistent with classical education. - The Newman Guide and related pages (DMA is highlighted as a recommended Catholic liberal-arts school) further signal alignment with a community that includes families in a shared mission.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families; co-educators; parent formation; family resources; parental engagement; home-school collaboration; open visits; Catholic cultural association; family resources. - Negative keywords present: none detected.

Why this rating - The school positions parents as co-educators and actively involves families in tours, admissions processes, and ongoing formation, which is characteristic of a classical community model.

Sources for evidence: Parent resources, family partnership language, and Newman Guide mention.

What Would Move the Needle

- Since the aggregate rating is CLASSICAL across all six categories, no major needle-moving changes are required. To further strengthen clarity, DMA could continue to:
- Document and publish specific classroom activities that demonstrate Socratic dialogue and Great Conversation-style pedagogy at more grade levels.
- Expand formal articulation of “living books” and explicit Great Books lists by grade bands to enhance transparency for prospective families.
- Highlight teacher professional development as formation of the living curriculum—e.g., faculty-led seminars on Catholic liberal education and virtuous pedagogy.

(If you want, I can convert these into a concrete action plan with timelines and metrics, but no further action is included here per the evaluation constraints.)

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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